

HARDIK CHHABRA

ONLINE FOOD DELIVERY

From 2008 onwards

Achievement:
The online food delivery market in India was Rs 80,000 crore in 2024

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"I order when the cook does not show up"

RIDHIMI KUKREJA, 36
Brand marketer, New Delhi

Ridhimi Kukreja has been using food delivery services ever since she started to live alone in Delhi for work. "When you're starting your career, you have some disposable income...so ordering in was very frequent, up to seven-eight times a week. Food delivery especially helped when you didn't like the meals prepared by the cook and one could quickly order momos or a pizza." For Ridhimi, what is useful in food delivery apps is not just that they offer a wide selection of restaurants and cafes, but also customer reviews, which makes it easy to try out new places and experiment with various cuisines.

"I order four to five times a week, mainly for convenience. After a long day at work, if the cook doesn't show up, it's much easier to order food or treat yourself to gourmet food on special occasions," she says. What's even better, says Ridhimi, is the availability of healthier options like salads and soups, which fit into her desire for a balanced lifestyle. ■

TastyKhana, TinyOwl and Ola Cafe also entered the market, but were eventually shut down, or acquired by larger competitors. Between 2016 and 2019, consulting firm RedSeer reported that the food delivery sector posted triple-digit growth for three consecutive years. Consumers wholeheartedly embraced the convenience these food delivery apps offered, exploring new cuisines and restaurants through discounts, coupons and cashback incentives.

In fact, convenience became the key driver, particularly among working professionals and young adults. Home-cooked meals started getting replaced with delivered options, fuelled by affordable prices, variety and quick service. The rising demand pushed players to expand their footprint, adding new restaurants and entering smaller cities. From just 15 cities in 2017, food-tech platforms grew to cover over 100 cities by 2018, estimates Redseer. These apps also created opportunities for cloud kitchens, which operate exclusively for takeaways. Today, India's food-tech market is dominated by Zomato and Swiggy. According to a Redseer, the market for India's online food services grew from Rs 30,000 crore in 2019 to Rs 80,000 crore in 2024.

Food apps have changed how urban Indians eat—they satisfy instant cravings, order gourmet meals and manage group orders, often multiple times a week for every individual. Everything is on the menu—from khichdi and salads to dosas and biryanis. ■